

Regional variation in Jespersen's Cycle in Early Middle English



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Introduction

- In this talk we investigate the onset of a change in negation patterns in the history of English.
- We carried out an exhaustive corpus study of texts from this period.
- Based on the regional variation we find, we ascribe the very early stage of the change to Scandinavian influence.

Jespersen's Cycle

- Named by Dahl (1979).

“The history of negative expressions in various languages makes us witness the following curious fluctuation: the **original negative** adverb is first weakened, then found insufficient and therefore **strengthened, generally through some additional word**, and this in its turn **may be felt as the negative proper** and may then in course of time be subject to the same development as the original word.” (Jespersen 1917: 4)

JC in French

- Stage 1: Old French *jeo* *ne* *dis* 'I don't say'
- Stage 2: Standard French *je* *ne* *dis* *pas*
(*pas* < 'a step')
- Stage 3: Colloquial French *je* *dis* *pas*



JC in English: Stage 1

- Stage 1: Verb is preceded by negative particle *ne* – the pattern inherited from OE.

(1) *swettore þing ne mizte be*

‘there could be no sweeter thing’

(corp145selt.tag)

JC in English: Stage 2

- Stage 2: *Ne* is reinforced – optionally at first – by a form such as *nawt*, *noht*, *naȝt* < OE *náwiht* ‘nothing’, normally placed after the verb.

(2) *he ne mai noȝte loke tilward her lyȝt*

‘he may not look toward her light’

(edincmct.tag)

JC in English: Stage 3

- Stage 3: *Ne* is lost, leaving *nawt/noht/naȝt* as the sole default marker of negation (> MnE *not*).

(3) *for godd aght noght gif yam mercy*
‘for God ought not to give them mercy’

(cotvespcmat.tag)



Regional variation?

- All three stages co-exist in Early ME.
- Wallage shows (2005, 2008) that the change from stage 2 to stage 3 (i.e. loss of *ne*) takes place during the ME period – but difficult to draw conclusions on regional variation using the PPCME2 (Kroch & Taylor 2000a) (2005: 68, 208).
- Ingham (2006: 90) shows for Late ME that *ne* is retained later in Southern and Midland texts than Northern texts.
- Iyeiri (1992: 78–85) mentions possible bias towards Stage III in Northern texts, on the basis of verse.
- Will we find similar regional variation by looking at Early ME?



LAEME

- LAEME (Laing 2013–) = A Linguistic Atlas of Early Middle English 1150–1325 (but contains a few texts 1325–1350).
- A 650,000-word lexico-grammatically tagged corpus of texts spanning the Early ME period.
- Approximate date and place of origin has been assigned to most texts.



Investigating JC

- Our search included all texts that (a) were dateable, (b) were localisable and (c) contained relevant tokens.
- Occurrences of stages 1, 2 and 3 in each text were counted.
- We are only interested in clausal negation, in which negation carries scope over the entire clause, rather than constituent negation using negative pronouns, negative adverbs, negative quantifiers, or constituent *not*.

Jack's law

- The development of constituent negation differs from that of clausal negation, in accordance with *Jack's law*:

A general rule, common to all the texts that I have examined, is that [stage 2] is not normally used in clauses containing other negative forms [...]. The group of negative forms normally incompatible with [stage 2] does not, however, include the conjunction *ne* 'nor', for [stage 2] is freely used in clauses introduced by or containing this conjunction [...]. (Jack 1978: 299)

- We counted contexts with 'nor' separately, in case it had any effect.



Contraction

- In stages 1 and 2, instead of *ne* one may find contracted prefix *n-* on some common verbs with initial V, /h/, /w/:

(4) *hy nuste ware hy were*

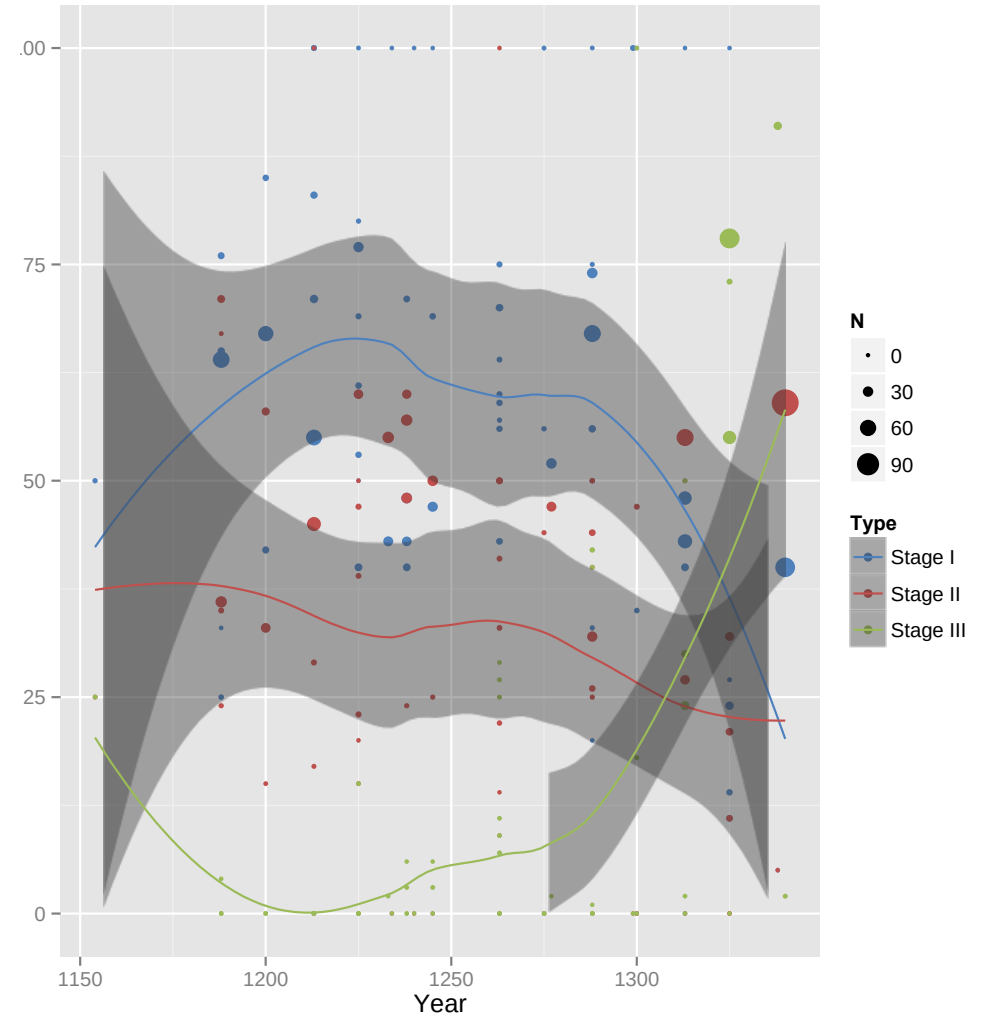
‘they didn’t know where they were’

(corp145selt.tag)

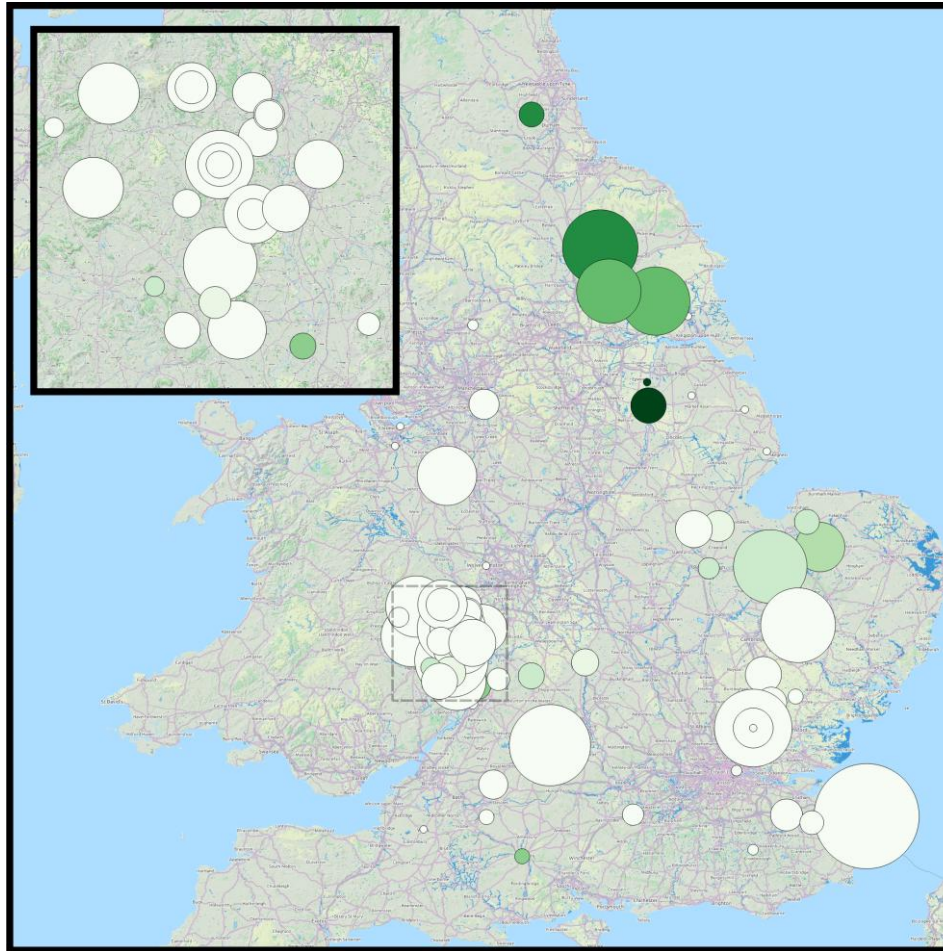
- Contracted tokens were also counted separately.

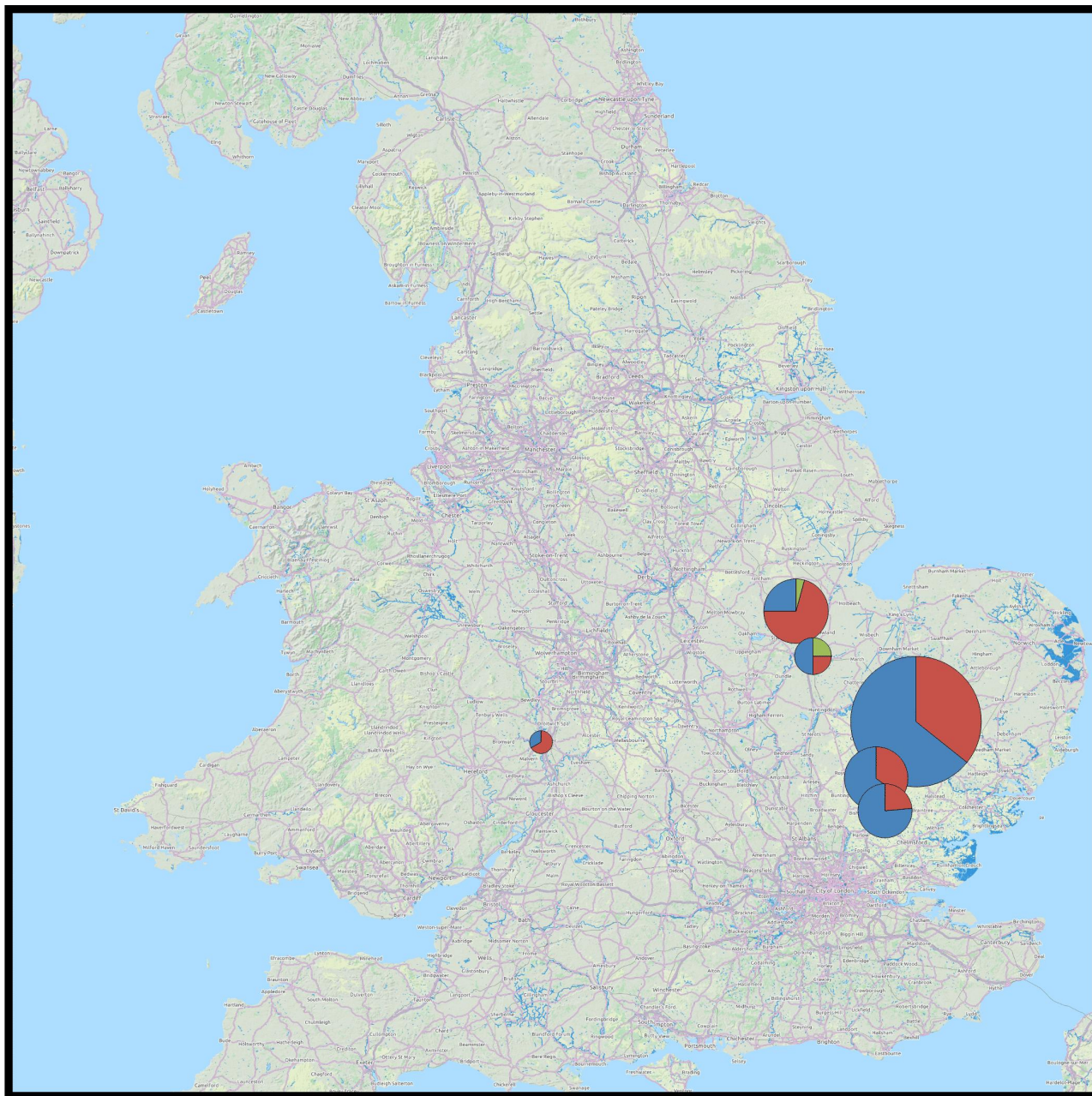
Results

Period	Stage 1	Stage 2	Stage 3	<i>n</i>
1150-1199	59.0%	39.3%	1.7%	173
1200-1249	55.9%	42.9%	1.2%	769
1250-1299	60.0%	34.6%	5.4%	442
1300-1350	32.1%	36.7%	31.3%	761



Maps





Maps

1150–1199



STAGE 1



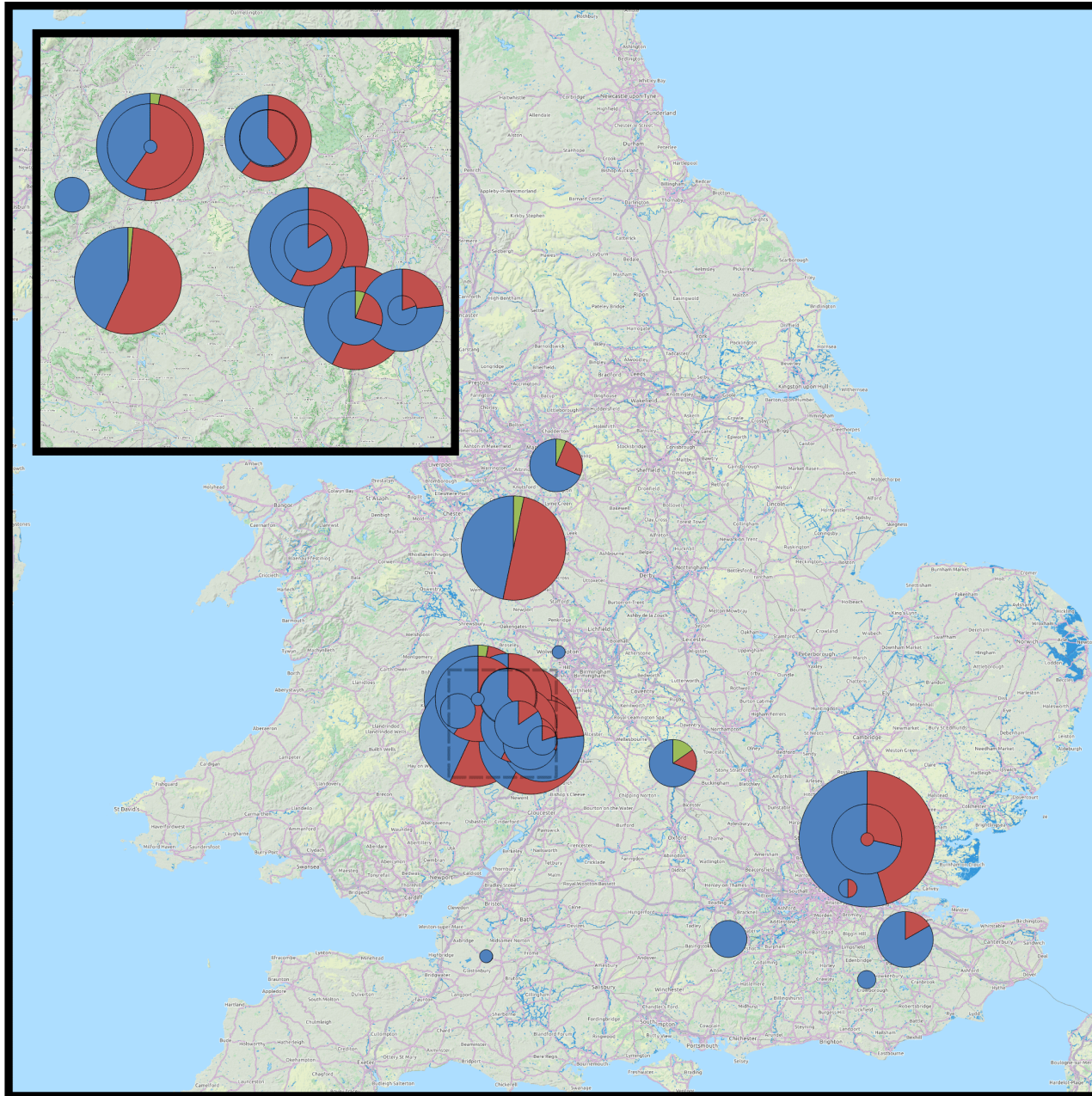
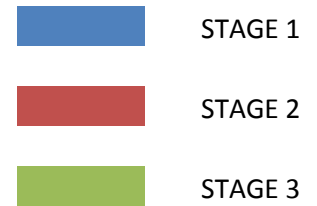
STAGE 2



STAGE 3

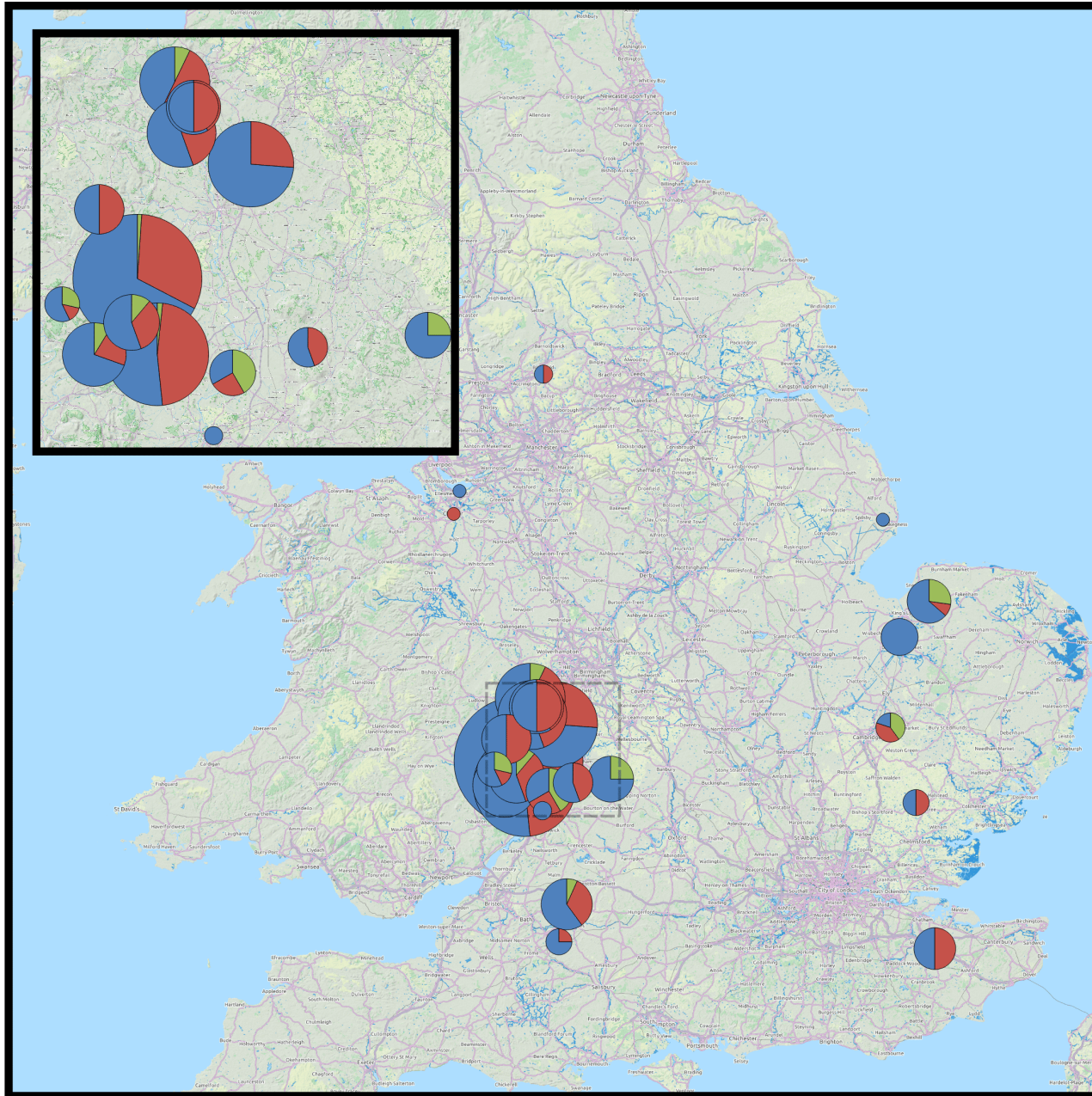
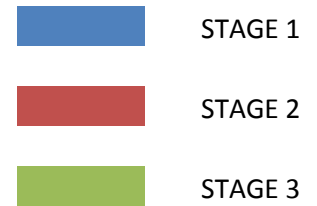
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1200–1249



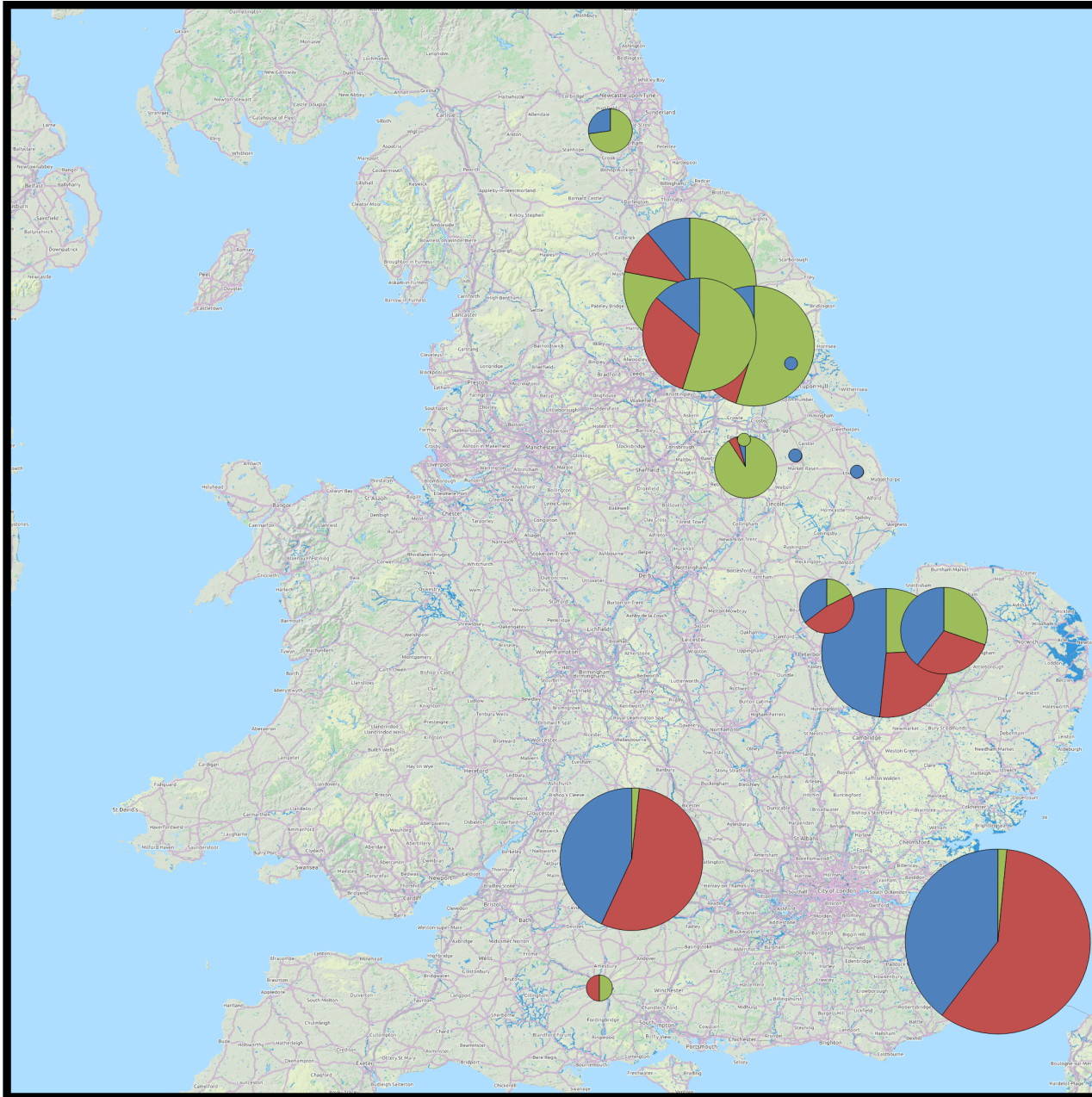
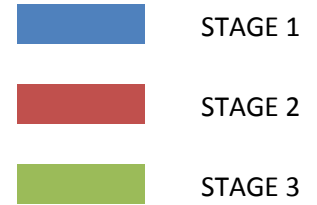
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1250–1299



Maps

1300–1350





Analysis

- Stage 3 is virtually non-existent during the first three time periods.
- When stage 3 appears in the fourth time period, it is mostly in the North and the East Midlands – areas with little or no representation in earlier periods.
- Therefore, the dramatic increase in stage 3 between the last two periods may not be real, as the change may have happened far earlier in these areas.
- Either way, it is clear that by the end of the Early ME period the North and the East Midlands were far more advanced in the change from stage 2 to stage 3 than the rest of England.

Results: Jack's Law

- Recall Jack's Law:

A general rule, common to all the texts that I have examined, is that [stage 2] is not normally used in clauses containing other negative forms [...]. The group of negative forms normally incompatible with [stage 2] does not, however, include the conjunction *ne* 'nor', for [stage 2] is freely used in clauses introduced by or containing this conjunction [...]. (Jack 1978: 299)

- We find that not only stage 2, but also stage 3, are significantly **less common** ($p < 0.01$ for the three later periods) in clauses introduced by or containing 'nor'.
- But effect size (Cramér's V) is low – never above 0.25.



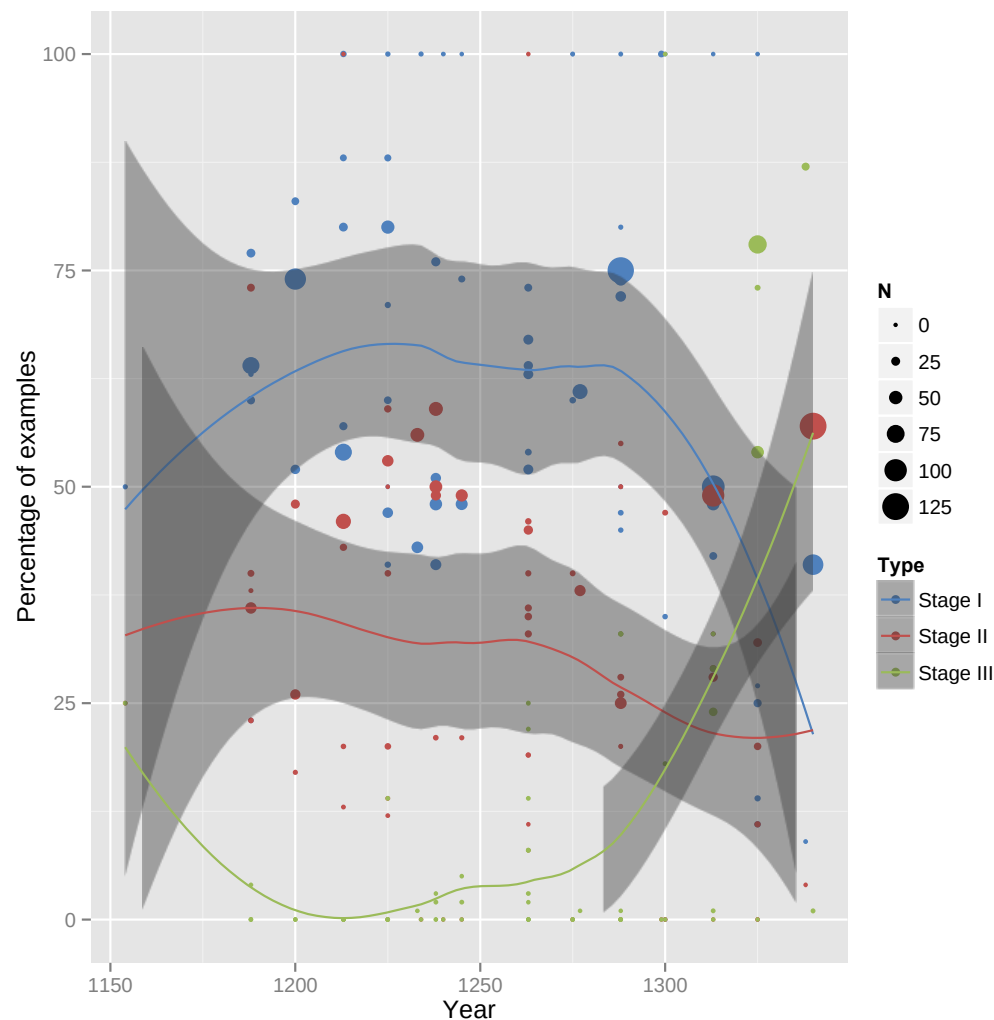
Results: Contraction

- Contracted tokens were counted separately.
- When these are included, the picture changes (a bit).
- Contraction favours stage 1 over stage 2;
 $p < 0.05$ for the three later periods.
- But effect size (Cramér's V) is again low – never above 0.12.

Results

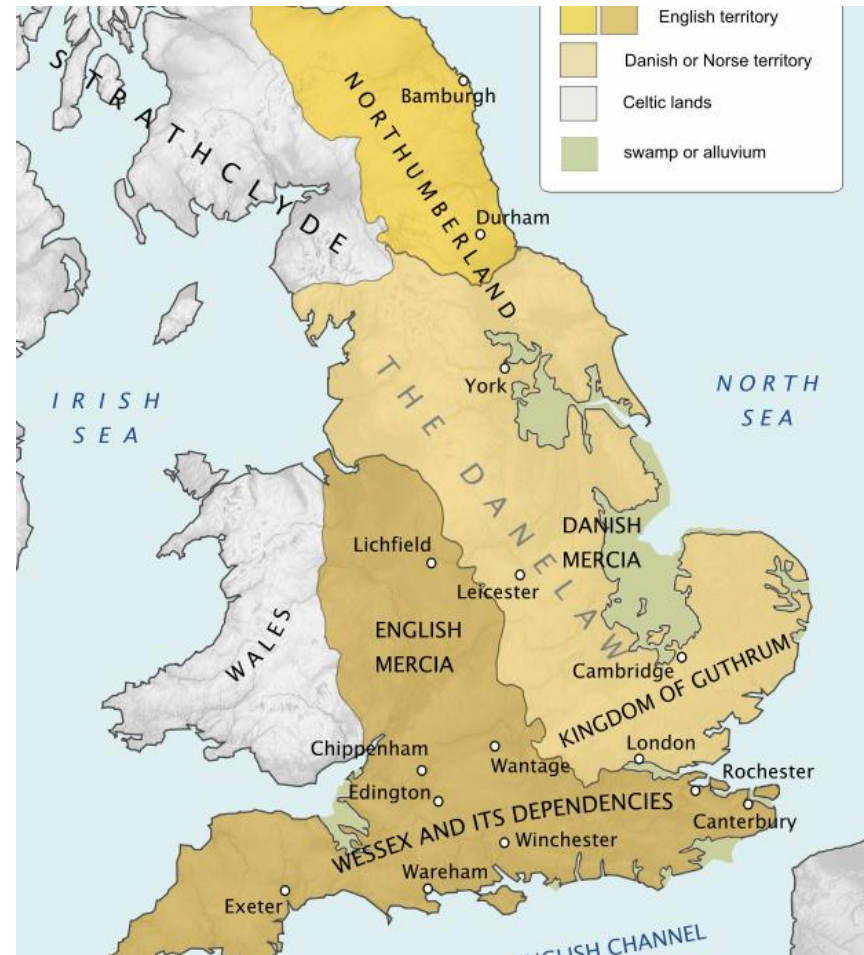
(incl. contraction)

1150–1199	Stage 1	Stage 2	n
Uncontracted	60.0%	40.0%	170
Contracted	63.6%	36.4%	44
1200–1249	Stage 1	Stage 2	n
Uncontracted	56.6%	43.4%	760
Contracted	62.8%	37.2%	379
1250–1299	Stage 1	Stage 2	n
Uncontracted	63.4%	36.6%	418
Contracted	74.1%	25.9%	328
1300–1350	Stage 1	Stage 2	n
Uncontracted	46.7%	53.3%	523
Contracted	59.2%	40.8%	120



Scandinavian influence

- Hypothesis: the change from stage 2 to stage 3 was catalysed by Scandinavian influence.
- Rationale: the area where Stage 3 is found first and most corresponds to the 9th–10th century Danelaw.



Map of Danelaw by Hel-hama, from Wikimedia Commons:

http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:England_878.svg



Sociolinguistic situation

- Norse speakers and (Old) English speakers co-existed at the community level.
- Townend (2002): Norse and Old English were *mutually intelligible*. Situation of “receptive multilingualism” (Braunmüller 2007).
- 11th-12th centuries see shift from Norse to English, with imposition (Townend 2002: 202-210) in the sense of Winford (2005).
 - Evidence: transfer of core vocabulary without phonological assimilation.



Negation in Old Norse

- Eypórrsson (2002):
 - JC stage 1 is prehistoric: earliest records have both preverbal *ni/ne* and postverbal *-a(t)* (stage 2)
 - *ni/ne* became optional and disappeared between C7th-C9th (stage 3)
 - C9th-C11th: postverbal *eigi* is innovated (stage 3)
 - Generally, *-a(t)* is only common in Old Icelandic, not Old Norwegian or Old East Norse, and only ever used with finite verbs, and lost by C14th.
- Stage 3 transferred to English via imposition?



What type of contact?

- Breitbarth & Walkden (2013): in general, short-term contact involving adult L2 acquisition is likely to lead to Stage 2 > 3 of Jespersen's Cycle ('simplification' in the terms of Trudgill 2011).
 - Evidence from Low German, French, and Dutch.
- Trudgill (2011: chapter 2) argues that contact between Norse and English was not the right type to lead to simplification.
- We don't need simplification for English, but...

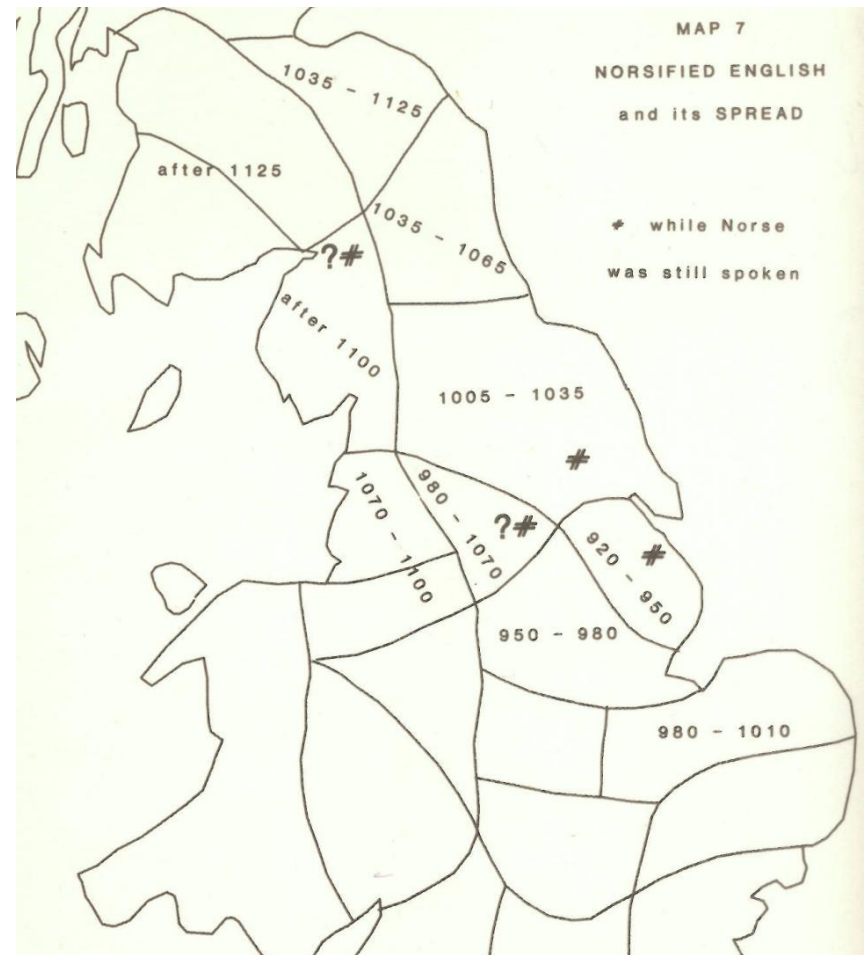


Time lag?

- Objection: isn't this period too late to be positing Scandinavian influence?
 - Thomason & Kaufman (1988: 282): shift almost complete by 1100
 - Townend (2002): shift occurred in C11th-C12th
- Answer: Yes, but we have almost no texts from the relevant area for the period preceding this.

The spread of Norsified English

- Thomason & Kaufman (1988): Norse features spread from Lindsey to Fourboroughs and Norfolk, then north
- Map from Thomason & Kaufman (1988: 338)



Specific texts (early)

Text	Period	Area	Stage 1	Stage 2	Stage 3	n
Peterborough Chronicle	1100-1149	Norfolk	50%	25%	25%	8
Ormulum	1150-1199	Fourboroughs	25%	71%	4%	24

- From areas with early and (comparatively) heavy Scandinavian settlement
- Literature on Scandinavian features in Ormulum is extensive
 - Other Norse-derived features (e.g. new third-person pronouns) used, but not categorically

Specific texts (late)

Text	Period	Area	Stage 1	Stage 2	Stage 3	n
Merton 248 Hand C	1300-1350	Lindsey	5%	5%	91%	22
Interludium de Clerico ...	1300-1350	Lindsey	0%	0%	100%	1
Cursor Mundi Hand B	1300-1350	Yorkshire	11%	11%	78%	100
Ballad on Scottish Wars	1300-1350	Co. Durham	27%	0%	73%	11

- *Interludium* localized to Axholme, NW Lincs (Laing 1997), and Merton 248 Hand C is close
- Cursor Mundi already discussed by Iyeiri (though different MS) – all above 50% Stage 3



Summary and conclusion

- In the Early Middle English period, Jespersen's Cycle was more advanced in Northern and East Anglian than in Southern and West Midlands texts.
- This may be due to contact with Scandinavian – specifically, imposition of Stage 3 through acquisition of English by Norse speakers during the process of language shift.



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